

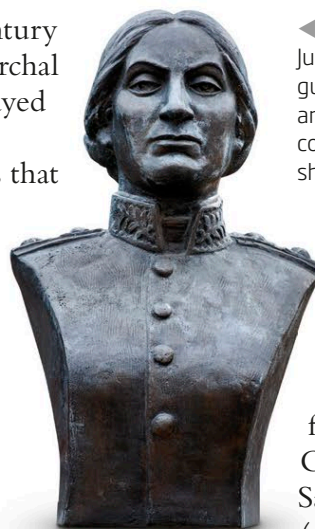
SPIES, SOLDIERS, AND victims

LATIN AMERICAN REVOLUTIONS

Latin America in the early 19th century was characterized by a deeply patriarchal system, but nevertheless women played an important role in the political upheavals, wars, and confrontations that occurred across the area from 1809 to 1825. This series of bloody revolutions against Spanish rule became known collectively as the Wars of Independence.

Heroines of the fight

While most women involved in these conflicts undertook noncombative, supporting positions, some women actively participated in guerrilla campaigns. An early heroine of the independence struggle was Micaela Bastidas, the wife of the rebel Tupac Amaru II. She fought beside her husband in an unsuccessful rebellion against Spanish rule in Peru in 1780. Due to the failure of the uprising, she and her husband were executed, along with Captain Tomasa Condemyata, who had successfully led her female battalion against the Spanish in several clashes.



◀ Complete commitment

Juana Azurduy de Padilla joined the Bolivian guerrilla forces to fight the Spanish regime and became a notable military leader. Her commitment to the cause was such that she even fought while she was pregnant.

Many women pushed their male relatives and husbands to fight for independence, as well as taking part themselves. Such female heroines as “Mother of Chile” Javiera Carrera and Policarpa Salavarrieta of Nueva Granada (present-day Colombia) were important underground fighters who spied for revolutionary forces. Often these women, like their male comrades, lost their lives as a result.

Several female revolutionaries became outstanding military leaders—for example, Juana Azurduy de Padilla, who fought for independence in Upper Peru (present-day Bolivia). Azurduy engaged in guerrilla warfare and fought in major



**“I AM GOING ... TO
ATTACK THEM [THE
ENEMY], EVEN IF IT
COSTS ME MY LIFE.”**

MICAELA BASTIDAS, IN A LETTER TO TUPAC AMARU II, 1780

*Policarpa Salavarrieta
Sacrificada p. los
ñoles en esta plaza
el 14 de Nov. de 1811
su memoria etc
entre nozotros y
fama rresuene d
á polo!!!*